

Have your neighbourhoods changed for the better in the last 10 years? Go *Vocal for Local*!

Do you see a new and improved public park in your locality? Do mobile health vans service your area? Can you use 1 app across all public transport in your city?

USD [19.5 billion+](#) have been spent over the last 10 years under the Smart Cities Mission (SCM). The promise of smarter infrastructure - backed by new technologies in information and communication - has been delivered on some fronts, but there is more to do.

- In large cities, only [3 out of 100 people](#) may benefit from the SCM projects.
- In [81%](#) of the SCM projects, only 1 out of 10 people will benefit.

The Smart City Mission requires robust changes:

As it is extended for the second time this year, the office of the Secretary of Housing and Urban Affairs invites discussions in the public realm about changes the ecosystem might benefit from.

In its current form the mission has several issues:

- Its project delivery timelines are [frequently extended](#)
- Infrastructural upgrades for urban mobility and digital governance [out-pace](#) those in education and health
- Urban solutions are [not localized](#) to Indian contexts
- Large scale developments are sometime not inclusive of everyone



Figure 1 Youtube Video Snippet - Community Participation and Planning | Akanksha Wakhare

Most of these issues can be worked on using the collaborative concepts of **participatory planning**. This will bring to the forefront every stakeholders' opinions at the most basic levels. Participatory discourse forms the fundamental socio-cultural framework under which projects should be taken up.

The office is going to facilitate participatory events which focus on local issue-solving via the [National Institute of Urban Affairs](#). The aim is to invite **academia, industry** and the **people** under a single umbrella for debates, research hackathons and design competitions periodically.

The Smart City Mission framework originally had several caveats to include citizen opinions in project designs, but the guidelines have been violated too liberally.

- Guidelines will now necessitate ranking of cities based on competitive indices that measure citizen collaboration, like in the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan.
- Guidelines will institutional redressal frameworks to ensure the promise of inclusivity.



The image shows a poster for the Swachh Survekshan Awards 2023. It features the title 'SWACHH SURVEKSHAN AWARDS 2023' at the top. Below the title is a table listing various awards and their winners. The table has two columns. The first column lists the award categories, and the second column lists the winning cities or organizations. The awards include All India Clean City Rank 1, All India Clean City Rank 3, All India Clean City Rank 1 (Population < 1 Lakh), All India Clean City Rank 2 (Population < 1 Lakh), All India Clean City Rank 3 (Population < 1 Lakh), Cleanest Cantonment Board, Best Safai Mitra Surakshit Sheher, Cleanest Ganga Town Rank 1, and Cleanest Ganga Town Rank 2. The winners are Indore & Surat, Navi Mumbai, Saswad, Patan, Lonavala, Mhow Cantonment Board, Chandigarh, Varanasi, and Prayagraj.

Award Category	Winner
All India Clean City Rank 1	Indore & Surat
All India Clean City Rank 3	Navi Mumbai
All India Clean City Rank 1 (Population < 1 Lakh)	Saswad
All India Clean City Rank 2 (Population < 1 Lakh)	Patan
All India Clean City Rank 3 (Population < 1 Lakh)	Lonavala
Cleanest Cantonment Board	Mhow Cantonment Board
Best Safai Mitra Surakshit Sheher	Chandigarh
Cleanest Ganga Town Rank 1	Varanasi
Cleanest Ganga Town Rank 2	Prayagraj

Figure 2: Swachh Bharat Abhiyan City Ranking | Press Information Bureau India

Suggestions are publicly invited for the formation and expansion of guidelines beyond the current scope. You can write to my office, or click on this [link](#).

Industry often has complained of complexity in the public-private partnership process - which delays the delivery of infrastructure projects. The ministry will be orchestrating round-tables via local administrations, to hear suggestions from respective local businesses and academia. Is your local administration not conducting one? Write to us about it at osdscm@nic.in.

In a little over a decade [40% of our nation will be living in urban areas](#). These will contribute to [70% of our GDP](#). It is very important to take cognizance of the upgradation of urban spaces that is required.

This blog will be sent to your email **every Wednesday** to further the conversation on urbanization and its many aspects. If you haven't already subscribed, click [here](#).

The office will add one podcast and one resource plainly explaining urban affairs to the end of this and all following Wednesday blogs.

This week, we have -

 - [Inclusive Cities with Nupur Prothi Khanna | NIUA TV](#)

 - [The Difference between Urban Planning and Urban Design in 100 Seconds | Mind the Map](#)

That is all for this week's blog. To suggest topics, to recommend podcasts and other urban affairs resources to our readers, write to us on our email niuablog@niua.in .